

Chapter

# Divine Wealth Is the True Lakshmi



## Introduction: Who Is Lakshmi?

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The moment Lakshmi Puja is mentioned, the mind conjures images of wealth, prosperity and money. But Acharya Upendra Ji gives a deeper definition of Lakshmi, one that comes straight from the sixteenth chapter of the Shrimad Bhagavad Gita:

"Daivi sampatti means everything described in the sixteenth chapter of the Bhagavad Gita — all of it. This is what is called Lakshmi."

In the first three verses of the Gita's sixteenth chapter, Lord Shri Krishna lists the **daivi sampada**, the divine wealth, that is, the divine qualities. Acharya Ji opens these qualities one by one and shows that **the more these qualities settle within us, the more genuine our Lakshmi Puja becomes.**

"How much of this comes into me — that is how well the Lakshmi Puja is going."

## 1. The First Verse: From Fearlessness to Simplicity

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abhayam sattva-saṁśuddhir jñāna-yoga-  
vyavasthitih  
dānam damaś ca yajñaś ca svādhyāyas tapa  
ārjavam

"Complete absence of fear, purity of the inner being, steadfastness in yoga for knowledge, charity, control of the senses, sacrifice, study of scripture, austerity and simplicity."

— Bhagavad Gita 16.1

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## Fearlessness: When There Is No "Other"

The first quality of divine wealth is **abhayam**, the complete absence of fear. Acharya Ji explains that the root of fear lies in the sense of an "other":

"When does the absence of fear come? When the feeling of non-duality comes — all is God. As long as there is an other, there can be fear."

"It can frighten me — an object, a person, a place, a job. Me and the job — so if the job goes, fear. Fear will come only when there is an other."

**Advaita**, "not two," the understanding that everything is the one Supreme, removes the very basis of fear:

"When the feeling of non-duality comes — it is my own creation — then it's fine, if this went, it went; another will come."

Yet Acharya Ji cautions in the same breath that fearlessness does not mean negligence: "If it goes, let it go — but not careless."

## Yoga, Charity, Restraint and Worship

Then come the rest of the verse's qualities: unbroken, firm steadiness in the yoga of meditation for the knowledge of truth, and charity. On charity, Acharya Ji makes clear which kind is meant:

"Sattvic charity — because charity is of three kinds."

"Restraint of the senses means control over the senses."

Then the worship of God, the deities and the gurus, the practice of noble acts such as Agnihotra, and the study and teaching of the Vedas and scriptures:

"Pathan-pathan — meaning both reading and teaching."

Along with these: singing the names and glories of God, bearing hardship to follow one's own dharma, and simplicity of the inner being together with body and senses. Acharya Ji asks:

"These qualities being described — what is their name? Daivi sampatti. It isn't over yet; only one verse is over, there are three verses. **That is Lakshmi only.**"

## 2. The Second Verse: From Non-Violence to Steadiness

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ahimsā satyam akrodhas tyāgaḥ śāntir apaiśunam  
dayā bhūteṣv aloluptvaṁ mārdaṁ hrīr  
acāpalam

"Non-violence, truthfulness, freedom from anger, renunciation, peace, refraining from slander, compassion for all beings, freedom from greed, gentleness, modesty and absence of restlessness."

— Bhagavad Gita 16.2

### Non-Violence: The Intention to Uplift, Even in Punishment

The first quality is not causing pain to anyone in any way, by mind, speech or body. But Acharya Ji makes clear that non-violence does not mean running from battle:

"So it was not said that you must not fight. Sama, dama, danda — there is danda, punishment, but in the punishment, his good."

"Mahishasuramardini killed Mahishasura, but for his liberation. Shri Krishna killed Kansa — for his liberation. So that is acceptable. The feeling in the mind is not one of hatred."

**Non-violence is less about the outer act than the inner feeling: there must be no hatred in the mind.**

### **Truth: The Art of Speaking Is Lakshmi**

The next quality is speech that is true and pleasant. Acharya Ji links it to the Upanishadic maxim:

"True and pleasant speech means — satyam vada, priyam vada, hitam vada."

That is: speak the truth, speak pleasantly, speak what is beneficial. Here he draws a beautiful distinction between Saraswati and Lakshmi:

"If that art comes to you, that is Lakshmi. Saraswati will give the knowledge, but to continuously maintain that way of speaking, knowing when to speak — that will come from Lakshmi Ji."

### **Freedom from Anger: A Calm Mind, Not Inaction**

The third quality is not feeling anger even towards someone who has wronged you. This does not mean injustice should simply be endured:

"It was not said that you should not teach him a lesson. You can do it with a calm mind, through planning — how to give back, treat on merit."

Acharya Ji gives the example of Chandragupta:

"Do I have the strength or not? When we look at Chandragupta — he was told that until he had the strength, he should not fight. First become a warrior, then go and fight. And for that too, a calm mind."

Why is anger harmful? Acharya Ji recalls the Gita's words from the third chapter:

**kāma eṣa krodha eṣa rajo-guṇa-samudbhavaḥ**

"It is desire, it is anger, born of the quality of rajas."

— Bhagavad Gita 3.37

"If there is a lot of rajoguna, then a great deal of desire will arise and a great deal of anger too. If the desire is not fulfilled, anger; if the desire is fulfilled, there will be ego."

Here Acharya Ji gives an important principle:

"That is why rajoguna is Lakshmi Ji, quite right, but it has to be supported with Saraswati too — only then does it become merit, only then does it become daivi sampatti."

The energy of rajas is Lakshmi; but only when joined with knowledge (Saraswati) does it become merit and divine wealth.

**A Mother's Anger: Not Enmity, but Correction**

Freedom from anger also does not mean parents may never scold their children. Recalling the Chanakya Niti line "dasha varshani tadayet" (discipline for ten years), Acharya Ji says:

"This doesn't mean you cannot be angry with your son. But in the middle of that shouting there is a feeling of love, the feeling 'may he improve'; there is no feeling of enmity towards him."

"Like a mother — when she hits her son, does she become his enemy? Even on that day she will not be his enemy."

**Forgiveness is also an option, and even if you must fight, you need a calm mind.**

### **Renunciation and Peace**

The next qualities are renouncing the pride of doership in actions, and the withdrawal of the inner being:

"Renouncing the pride of doership in actions — meaning there should be no ego."

"Withdrawal of the inner being, that is, the absence of restlessness of the mind."

### **Apaishunam: Not Slander, but Constructive Correction**

Then comes not slandering anyone. Acharya Ji clarifies that this does not mean a total ban on criticism:

"You can do constructive criticism, in which there is his good — that is acceptable. If, hurt by your words, he is going to fall, going to go down, then there is no benefit."

He gives a vivid household example: a daughter-in-law who does not do the housework:

"She may have come from a royal family, she may be like that, or there was pampering at home. Now you have a different culture, you have a lot of work."

"So if, by saying again and again 'you are like this, you are like that, your mother gave you no values,' you reduce her personality to zero — you commit her brahma-hatya — then you will not achieve anything; on the contrary, you will incur sin."

"But show her what the importance of work is, show her by doing it — that will work."

**Not breaking someone with words, but showing them by doing it yourself: this is the divine way of correction.** Acharya Ji also points to Kabir's teaching: "The critic's house should be close by," meaning keep those who criticise you near, but do not slander others.

### **Compassion Without Motive**

The next quality is compassion towards all beings, without motive. **Hetu** means a reason or self-interest. Acharya Ji points to today's popular "remedies":

"What does hetu mean? This — I will benefit. I fed this much to the pigeons, so my debt will be cleared. I gave this much to the cow, to the dog, so Shani will be set right. Give this much to the pigeons and I'll get married."

"None of that. You must be compassionate, but without motive."

**Compassion as a bargain is not divine wealth; compassion is divine only when it expects nothing in return.**

After this: having no attachment to sense objects even when the senses come into contact with them, and gentleness.

### **Modesty: Before Society and Before Scripture**

Then comes shame at conduct that goes against society and scripture. Acharya Ji describes two sides of it. The first is shame before society:

"You'll go to some beach — like a Goa beach or some Miami beach — and if people there are shameless, anything is going on there, then there is shame before society."

The second is shame before scripture, when we say "everyone is doing it" and start doing the same:

"There you'll say, 'Oh, everyone is doing that, so I did it too' — then the shame of scripture should come."

And sometimes something looks right by scripture but goes against social decorum:

"Puja and prayers are all going on, meaning it is in line with scripture — but behind it, DJ music playing and other mess; that kind of puja is going on."

"Correct by one, but if the other is wrong, then I should feel shame in it — I should get up and leave. So that tendency that arises, what is it called? Daivi sampatti."

**Absence of Futile Activity**

The last quality of the second verse is the absence of futile activity. Acharya Ji connects it to modern life:

"Meaning your unwanted serials or some gossip — all this is called futile activity."

"Watching all this unnecessarily, sitting and watching short videos, two, four hours at a time — it is futile activity, unless it is for some reason, some knowledge is coming from it."

"So this was the second verse. All of this comes under Lakshmi."

### 3. The Third Verse: From Radiance to Humility

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tejaḥ kṣamā dhṛtiḥ śaucam adroho nāti-mānitā  
bhavanti sampadam daivīm abhijātasya bhārata

"Radiance, forgiveness, fortitude, outer purity,  
absence of enmity towards anyone and absence of  
pride in being worshipped — O Bharata, these are  
the marks of one born with divine wealth."

— Bhagavad Gita 16.3

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#### Tej: The Radiance Before Which People Change

Acharya Ji first reads the definition of **tej**:

"Tej is the name of that power of great souls by whose  
influence even people attached to sense pleasures and  
of base nature usually stop their unjust conduct in their  
presence and engage in noble deeds as they direct."

Then he gives examples:

"How Valya becomes Valmiki — instantly, from one sentence spoken — that is the radiance of speech. Or when Chanakya Ji spoke, the whole village would listen — that is called tej."

And he shares the experience of his own camps:

"Recently we taught the Aahar Shibir, and many people said, 'Oh, we've given up non-veg.' We taught the Brahmacharya Shibir, and many young men said, 'Oh, we've even given up our debauchery.' So that is called tej."

Where does this radiance come from?

"Because of what does tej come? It was said — the practice of brahmacharya. Then tej, and after that come the power of intellect, and so on."

## **Forgiveness and Fortitude**

Then forgiveness and fortitude. Acharya Ji defines fortitude in simple words:

"Dhairya means holding on something for very long time."

And he unpacks the meaning of **dhira purusha**, the steadfast person:

"His dhi — meaning intellect — is sound and stable; such a person is called a dhira purusha. The one who held on with patience all the way to samadhi — only he is called a dhira purusha."

### **Purity, Absence of Enmity and Humility**

"Outer purity — outer, meaning external — is needed in any case."

Then: having no feeling of enmity towards anyone. Here too Acharya Ji reminds us that this does not mean giving up one's rights:

"Meaning, you should fight — sama, dama, danda — for required rights."

And the last quality, the absence of pride in being worshipped:

"Meaning not 'I am someone great, worthy of worship';  
God is working through me — God first."

## 4. This Is Mahalakshmi

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Having completed the three verses, Acharya Ji gathers the whole teaching into one word:

"So this daivi sampatti, what is it called in simple language? Mahalakshmi. Lakshmi basically is all this."

And then he asks a pointed question:

"All the puja done all these years until now — was this what you asked for? And where in this was money mentioned?"

The one saying this is no ordinary speaker:

"Shri Krishna — Lakshmi is his own consort, he is Vishnu himself — and he himself is telling Arjuna, 'See.'"

He who is himself Vishnu, the Lord of Lakshmi, introduces Lakshmi not through wealth, but through divine qualities.

## 5. Demonic Wealth: The Path of Bondage

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In the following verses, the Lord also describes the opposite of divine wealth:

**dambho darpo 'bhimānaś ca krodhaḥ pārūṣyam  
eva ca**

**ajñānaṁ cābhijātasya pārtha sampadam āsurīm**

"O Partha, hypocrisy, arrogance, pride, anger, harshness and ignorance — these are the marks of one born with demonic wealth."

— Bhagavad Gita 16.4

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**daivī sampad vimokṣāya nibandhāyāsūrī matā  
mā śucaḥ sampadam daivīm abhijāto 'si pāṇḍava**

"Divine wealth is held to lead to liberation, and  
demonic wealth to bondage. Do not grieve, O  
Pandava, for you are born with divine wealth."

— Bhagavad Gita 16.5

**Divine wealth liberates, demonic wealth binds:** this is the  
root difference between the two.

## **6. The Lakshmi Hidden Within the Seeker**

The Lord assured Arjuna, "You are born with divine wealth."  
Acharya Ji gives the same assurance to every seeker:

"So by default, if you are a seeker, these qualities are  
within you somewhere."

These qualities need not be brought from anywhere; only the  
veil over them must be removed:

"So you only have to go to the Guru and uncover it, unlock it — all that veil that has fallen over it."

But the case of one with demonic wealth is different:

"The one who has demonic wealth within has no inclination to give — it will be very hard to change him."

The seed of giving is already in the seeker, and that is what has brought them to Lakshmi Puja:

"At least you have all this within you, a little at least, something was there. The wish to give, in the form of wealth, must have arisen at some point — that is why you are here today at the Lakshmi Puja."

"In general, out there, all three kinds of people are doing Lakshmi Puja; it does not bear fruit for everyone."

## Summary: Key Teachings

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- 1 The true Lakshmi is divine wealth,** the divine qualities described in the sixteenth chapter of the Gita. The more these qualities settle within us, the more meaningful our Lakshmi Puja becomes.
- 2 Fearlessness comes from non-duality.** As long as there is an "other," there is fear; when the feeling "all is God" comes, fear disappears. But fearlessness does not mean carelessness.
- 3 Non-violence and freedom from anger are about the inner feeling.** There can be punishment, struggle and scolding, but with no hatred in the mind, only the wish to uplift and correct, and with a calm mind.
- 4 Rajas is Lakshmi, but it needs the support of Saraswati (knowledge);** only then does it become merit and divine wealth.
- 5 Don't slander; show by doing.** Constructive criticism is fine, but crushing someone's personality with words is a sin.

- 6 **Compassion must be without motive.** Charity and kindness done in hope of gain are a bargain, not divine wealth.
- 7 **Avoid futile activity.** Pointless serials, gossip and hours of short videos also diminish divine wealth.
- 8 **Radiance comes from brahmacharya,** and that radiance turns others towards noble deeds.
- 9 **Divine wealth liberates, demonic wealth binds.** These qualities are already within the seeker; going to the Guru, the veil over them must be removed.